

KEY DATA

Size ranking 65

Brightest stars Alpha (α) 3.7, Beta (β) 4.0

Genitive Pyxidis

Abbreviation Pyx

Highest in sky at 10pm February–March

Fully visible 52°N–90°S



CHART 6

MAIN STARS

Alpha (α) Pyxidis
Blue-white giant

☼ 3.7 ↔ 879 light-years

Beta (β) Pyxidis
Yellow giant

☼ 4.0 ↔ 416 light-years

Gamma (γ) Pyxidis.
Orange giant

☼ 4.0 ↔ 207 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

NGC 2818

Planetary nebula

Gamma (γ) Pyxidis
An orange giant about 200 light-years away, and magnitude 4. With Beta Pyxidis, it is joint second brightest

T Pyxidis
This variable star, also classed as a recurrent nova, is 15,600 light-years away. In 2011, it temporarily changed in magnitude from 15 to 6.8

Alpha (α) Pyxidis
The brightest star in Pyxis, Alpha Pyxidis is six times the Sun's size, 10 times its mass, and 10,000 times more luminous

Beta (β) Pyxidis
A yellow giant star, twice the distance of Gamma Pyxidis, about seven times its size, and shining just as brightly in the sky

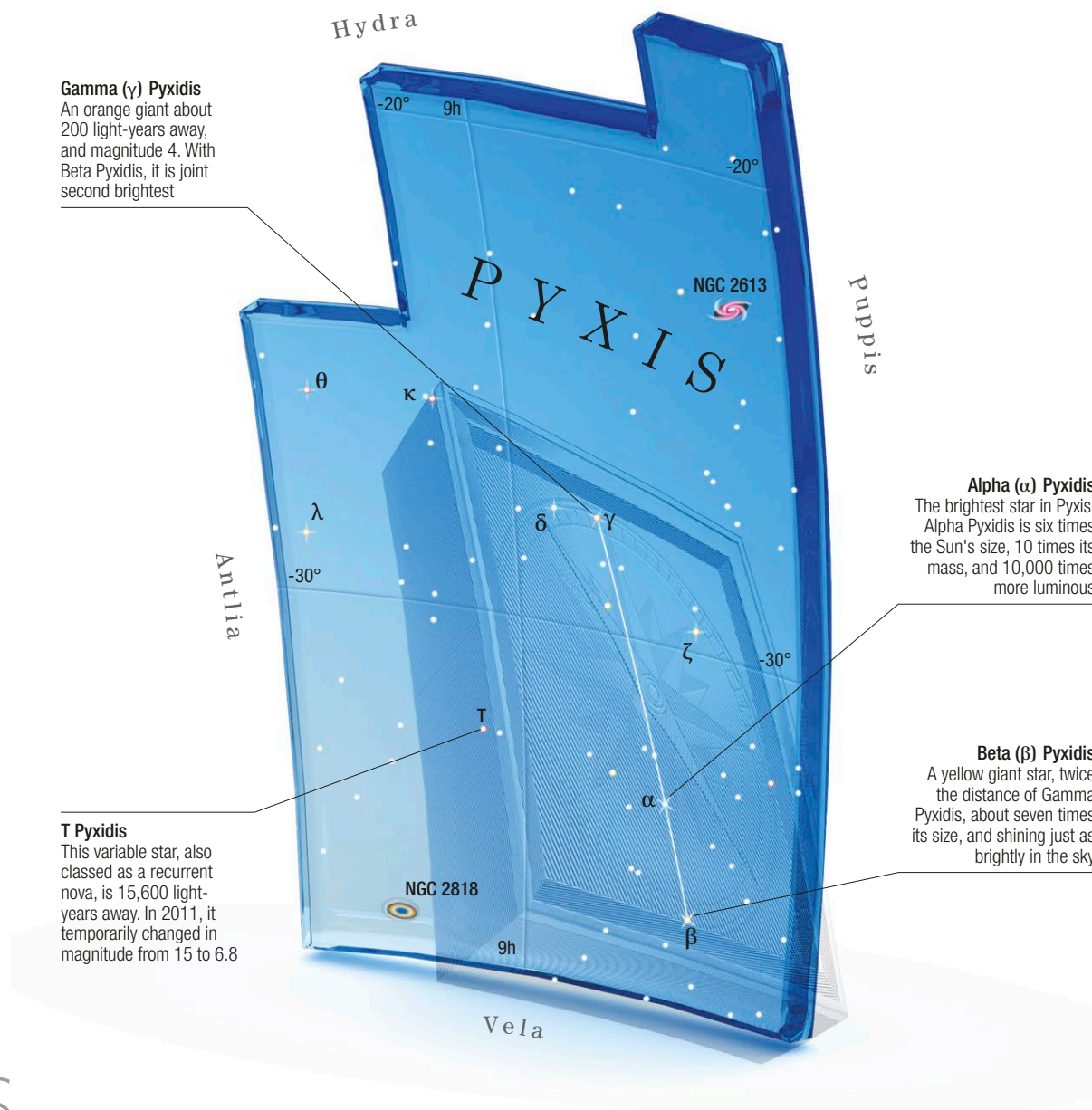
PYXIS

THE COMPASS

THIS IS A SMALL CONSTELLATION ON THE EDGE OF THE MILKY WAY WHOSE PATTERN IS A ROW OF THREE STARS. PYXIS IS A MAGNETIC COMPASS INTRODUCED TO THE SOUTHERN SKY IN THE 1750s.

Pyxis was devised by the French astronomer Nicholas Louis de Lacaille. After sailing south in 1750 and setting up an observatory at Cape Town, he catalogued the stars of the southern sky and formed some of these into 14 new constellations. The compass is the sort used by seamen and is fittingly next door to Puppis, the ship's stern.

With deep-sky objects such as the barred spiral galaxy NGC 2613 only visible with a large amateur telescope, the constellation's notable objects are its stars. The variable star T Pyxidis consists of a white dwarf pulling material onto its surface from a larger companion. This causes the white dwarf to erupt unpredictably and increase dramatically in brightness. Its last eruption in 2011 was the first since 1966.



△ NGC 2818

More than 10,000 light-years away, this planetary nebula is a star in the process of dying. The outer layers of a once Sun-like star have been pushed off into space. In their center is a white dwarf, the central remains of the original star. Red represents nitrogen, hydrogen is shown in green, and blue is oxygen.